

Ford 5-AT Tri-Motor



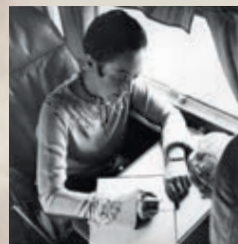
"I should like one thousand dollars, and I can only promise one thing. You'll never see the money again."

AIRPLANE BUILDER WILLIAM STOUT
TO HENRY FORD'S SON, EDSSEL



IN-FLIGHT MEALS

Chicken salad was the staple centerpiece of the in-flight meals served during the pioneering years of passenger flight in the late 1920s. Air stewardesses became a feature of passenger travel from the early 1930s onward.



SLICK IMAGERY

A publicity shot emphasises the comfort and smoothness of flight on board a Ford Tri-Motor, qualities that were in short supply on most flights. Vibration was a problem experienced by passengers on all propeller-driven airliners.

AUTOMOBILE MANUFACTURER Henry Ford, creator of the Model T, had a reputation second to none as a hard-headed businessman. When he announced an interest in airplane manufacturing in 1924, the whole American business community sat up and took notice. Ford declared that he looked forward to a time when aircraft could be mass-produced like automobiles "by the thousands or by the millions". This was overambitious, but at least with the Tri-Motor – affectionately known as the "Tin Goose" – Ford made the first American passenger-carrier to be produced in the hundreds.

In the 1920s, Europeans were world leaders in airplane design.

To come up with a successful commercial airplane, Ford's team put together a hybrid of features from the Fokker and Junkers stables. Ford incorporated a small company run by engineer Bill Stout, who was making all-metal aircraft with a corrugated tin skin in the Junkers style. The "tin" was aluminium and aluminium alloy. The story goes that after Richard Byrd's attempted flight to the North Pole in a Fokker, Byrd made a stop at Ford's Dearborn Field. Here the plane was secretly measured up by Ford engineers so that they could copy it for their prototype.

Ford's Tri-Motor 4-AT (Air Transport), which was introduced in 1926, was succeeded in 1928 by

Specifications (5-AT-B)

ENGINE	3 x 420hp Pratt & Whitney Wasp radials
WINGSPAN	77ft 10in (23.7m)
LENGTH	49ft 10in (15.2m)
WEIGHT	13,000lb (5,897kg)
TOP SPEED	110mph (176kph)
PASSENGERS	15
CREW	2

